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Alesia Rudnik

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Practices and Agencies in the Belarusian Protests of 2020: Perspectives of Protest Participants and Leaders

ALESIA RUDNIK

Abstract

This article explores the roles of digital platforms, protesters and protest organisers in mobilising and coordinating prodemocratic protests in Belarus in summer 2020. Following the actors in the network of the Belarusian protests of August 2020, and drawing on Latour's actor–network theory, I examine protest-related practices and types of agency in these protests by engaging with the opinions and reflections of protesters, activists, politicians and moderators of the leading Telegram channels who participated in the protests. I argue that these Belarusian protests produced multiple agencies and transformed Telegram into a mediator with agency rather than merely a tool in the hands of protesters.

INFORMATION AND COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGIES HAVE played a significant role in mobilisation, coordination and communication of protest movements in autocratic states during the last few decades (Tufekci 2013; Breuer *et al.* 2015; Tucker *et al.* 2018; Brantly 2019). Recent protest episodes in Hong Kong, Belarus, Russia and the US have sparked interest in the capacity of new digital platforms such as Telegram and TikTok to promote and organise street action (Jiang *et al.* 2022; Wijermars & Lokot 2022). The anonymity and encryption provided to users, the specific affordances of these platforms and the popularity of a platform within a country can help to explain the choice of social networking platform by activists (Jost *et al.* 2018; Jiang *et al.* 2022). Social movements and democratisation scholars have recognised the role of social media, messaging apps and other digital platforms in distributing information about protest logistics, circulating live updates and gathering volunteer support, as well as influencing the creation of a group identity and the feeling of ownership of a political agenda (Tufekci 2013; Breuer & Groshek 2014; Jost *et al.* 2018; Clarke & Kocak 2020).

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These ideas about the relationship between activism and information and communications technologies leads one to look beyond the use of social media platforms as mere tools and opens the way to exploring them from a new perspective: their role as actors or mediators. Media scholars have highlighted the importance of these platforms in mediating relationships, interactions and political action during organised collective action (van Dijck 2013). Social media thus appear to be ‘online facilitators or enhancers of human networks—webs of people that promote connectedness as a social value’ (van Dijck 2013, p. 11). Protest networks within which human and non-human actors and actants interact can strengthen solidarity, a movement’s longevity and the network itself (Fang 2023, p. 9). Digital platforms are represented as possessing an ‘actorness’ which, through performativity and delegation practices, becomes part of the socio-technical networks that emerge during protest episodes (van Dijck 2013; Wijermars & Lokot 2022). Telegram is one example of a social media and messaging platform studied as possessing agency and mediating protests (Wijermars & Lokot 2022).

Telegram’s role during the large-scale protests in Belarus in 2020 sparked interest among political scientists and social movements and media scholars when it emerged as a new mediation and mobilisation platform. During the protests, Telegram served as a platform informing users about protests, expanding their scale and strengthening horizontal connections between protesters (Herasimenka *et al.* 2020; Kazharski 2021; Mateo 2022; Wijermars & Lokot 2022). Mateo (2022) and Wijermars and Lokot (2022) analysed the content of protest-related channels (broadcasting channels managed by editorial teams) and group chats (open groups with possibilities for anyone to enter and broadcast), and described Telegram’s affordances as significant in shaping the Belarusian protests. This platform-oriented analysis has made a significant contribution to the understanding of Telegram as a vehicle for the protest movement in Belarus by highlighting it as a secure platform with a user-friendly interface that enables rapid dissemination of protest-related information across the country, enhancing mobilisation (Rogers 2020; Mateo 2022; Rudnik & Rönnblom 2024). However, despite these promising developments, scholarship has not engaged with the experiences of Telegram users during the protests or with the content producers and mediators, such as moderators of the Telegram channels used during the protests. Nor has it engaged with the politicians and activists who used the platform for communicating their political messages.

Considering the increasing intimacy of human–technology relations, including in political dissent, an understudied but potentially illuminating way of addressing the role of technologies in political protests is through the concept of agency developed within the analytical framework of actor–network theory (ANT). This framework proposes that we should treat technology and humans as mutual counterparts interacting within assemblages or networks enacted under particular circumstances and co-producing specific types of relations that are otherwise impossible (Latour 2004).

This article examines the agencies that emerged in the coordination, mediation and communication of protests in Belarus in 2020. The study builds on 38 in-depth interviews with protesters, opposition politicians and moderators of the biggest Telegram channels, such as NEXTA Live, NEXTA, Belarus Golovnogo Mozga and Maja Kraina Belarus, during the protests in Belarus during the summer of 2020. The analysis is based on a recognition of the agency of technology in social and political processes, understood as

the ability of both human and non-human actors to modify, activate and render new modes of action, and to promote new types of relations between the elements of the socio-technical network (Latour 2004; van Dijck 2013; Sayes 2014). In line with this idea, this study aims to understand the enactment of protests in Belarus in 2020 by asking, first, what protest practices were invoked by the socio-technical network in the Belarusian protests of 2020; and second, how the human and non-human agencies triggered by these protest practices can be conceptualised.

The article starts with the background of protests and activism in Belarus and presents previous research on Telegram in relation to the protests in Belarus. I then discuss theoretical arguments on technology, social media platforms and protest practices by focusing on the concept of agency. The third section describes the gathering and analysis of empirical material. The fourth section analyses interview material divided according to the interviewed groups: protesters; activists and politicians; and the moderators of the Telegram channels mobilising protest. This section also discusses the empirical findings in relation to the concept of agency.

The analysed materials illustrate how the power of social media and messaging apps extends beyond the concept of a tool or resource mobilised by rational actors to organise revolution or protests, giving protests a new shape (Johnson 1988; Cockburn & Ormrod 1993).

Belarus's political context and previous political protests

Following the breakdown of the USSR, Belarus's first elected president, Alyaksandr Lukashenka, moved towards an authoritarian consolidation of power (Bennett 2011). Over the years of his rule, Lukashenka has secured a political regime with centralised economic management and limited civil liberties, freedom of speech and political rights (Levitsky & Way 2010). Contested at the presidential elections in 2001, 2006 and 2010, the Lukashenka regime responded brutally to any electoral challenge or street action (Chulitskaya & Matonyte 2025). In 2006, when Belarusians protested the election results, mobilisation occurred primarily through the offline networks of oppositional parties and organisations under the leadership of several oppositional candidates (De Vogel 2022). The protests that followed the electoral campaign of 2010, attracting thousands of Belarusians to the streets of Minsk, were similarly mobilised. Both episodes resulted in violent oppression by the regime, while 2010 was also marked by the arrest of seven other presidential candidates, along with the violent crackdown and detention of over a thousand peaceful protesters (Marples 2006; De Vogel 2022).

The first series of protests that actively incorporated the social media platform V Kontakte took place in 2011. Labelled by protesters as a 'revolution through social media' and 'silent actions', protests occurred across Belarus (Navumau 2019). There was another wave of protests, smaller in scale, in 2017, when the authorities announced fines for citizens registered as unemployed for at least half a year (Giles 2017). In both episodes, social media was used to spread anti-governmental narratives, make demands for abolishing unemployment tax (an annual fine that Belarusians pay to the state if they are unemployed for over 180 days) and mobilise dissent (Navumau 2019). In 2019 another series of protests, mobilised primarily through social media, opposed the integration of

Russia and Belarus, laid out by the so-called integration maps signed between the Belarusian and Russian governments (Moshes & Nizhnikau 2021). Previous studies show that activists perceive social media as a vital tool of communication and mobilisation in Belarus, although there has been regime pressure on opinion leaders on social media to practise self-censorship (Pospieszna & Galus 2019; Rudnik 2020).

In contrast to previous episodes, in 2020 several factors significantly increased incentives for participation in protests: the government's poor management and denial of the COVID-19 pandemic, which had a negative economic impact; the unexpected announcement by banker Viktor Babaryka, blogger Siarhei Tsikhanouski and former official Valery Tsapkala that they would run for the presidency, followed by the arrest of Lukashenka's main opponents, Babaryka and Tsikhanouski;¹ and finally, the rigged election and violence against protesters during the first day of protests (Bedford 2021; Kazharski 2021).² The 2020 protests saw the large-scale engagement of citizens in cities and smaller residential areas (Mateo 2022). By some estimates, over 18% of the country's adult population were involved (Onuch & Sasse 2022). On the eve of the election week, several electoral monitoring initiatives emerged with a view to ensuring the election's transparency: Sumlennyya Liudzi (Honest People) invited Belarusians to become election observers at their local polling stations, Zubr (Bison) collected information and reported on electoral violations through a designated webpage on electoral fraud, while *Holas* (Voice) offered a platform for Belarusians willing to take part in simultaneous alternative digital voting. Digital platforms, such as Telegram, Viber, Instagram played a decisive role by disseminating information and coordinating protests, which I address by referring to previous research and interview materials further in the article.

Arguably, the protests of 2020 disrupted the stability and legitimacy of the Belarusian regime (Hall 2023). However, further political developments, such as the involvement of the Belarusian regime in Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the unprecedented brutality and scale of political repression, and the crackdown on independent media and the civil society sector, allowed the Belarusian regime to maintain its political power.

The scale of citizen engagement makes the Belarusian protests one of the largest such episodes in an authoritarian state since the Arab Spring (Onuch & Sasse 2022). A wider literature takes a bottom-up approach to large-scale protests in Middle East and North Africa (Tufekci 2013; Breuer *et al.* 2015). However, empirical research on protest participants in Belarus in 2020 is rather limited. Inspired by the expanding literature on digital technology's role in the 2020 protests in Belarus (Mateo 2022; Onuch & Sasse 2022; Wijermars & Lokot 2022), this article examines the nuanced relationship between digital technology and human actors (protesters, protest organisers, digital activists and moderators of Telegram channels) during the protests against the authoritarian regime in Belarus. Against this backdrop, the study contributes to wider knowledge of political mobilisation in authoritarian regimes, focusing not only on the digital platforms but also on the individuals involved, who have been largely excluded from research on the Belarusian protests to date.

¹Tsikhanouski's wife took over the campaign as the primary opposition candidate.

²'Final Report on 2020 Presidential Elections in Belarus', Voice, 2020, available at: <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1WnyAfVKDhZQOxxDd2tdi5xcH3eiOng0V/view>, accessed 29 April 2025.

Technology in the context of protests

A broad literature on social movements, democratisation, media and communication, and the internet has contributed to our understanding of the role of social networking platforms and the internet in social movements and civic uprisings by expanding conceptualisations of mobilisation strategies, mobilisation repertoires and communication practices (Tufekci 2013; Breuer & Groshek 2014; Jost *et al.* 2018; Clarke & Kocak 2020). Previous research has addressed the functions and effects triggered by new social networking platforms, such as Telegram and TikTok (Jiang *et al.* 2022). Political events such as the Arab Spring in the 2010s, Euromaidan in 2013–2014 and Gezi Park protests of 2013 have triggered research interest in social networking platforms as vehicles for protest mobilisation (Tufekci 2013; Breuer *et al.* 2015; Jost *et al.* 2018).

Similarly, the significant role of Telegram in the Belarusian protests has prompted scholars to investigate the political usage of the platform and its incorporation into a social movement. Telegram presents a novel context in which the platform mediating political protests provides a basis for a political analysis of relations between humans and everyday technology activated to demand political change. Telegram's popularity surged on the eve of the protest, with a record number of users signing up to the app. This was the result of an information campaign by activists and independent media, who, weeks before election day, warned citizens about a possible internet shutdown, and suggested that installing a VPN and joining Telegram would enable them to circumvent this.³ Expecting the internet shutdown during the crucial election days, both independent media, mobilisation channels, politicians and ordinary citizens moved to the platform to secure access to information. The unprecedented surge in audience numbers gave rise to large Telegram channels that actively participated in protest moderation. NEXTA Live, the most popular channel, which by the start of the protests was led from abroad, had reached 1.5 million subscriptions by election day, when the protests started, a figure five times larger than during the days before the protests (Bykov *et al.* 2021).

From the outset of the Belarusian protests in summer 2020, Telegram aggregated the channels of opposition politicians, civic activists and independent media, as well as hosted personalised and anonymous channels with hundreds of thousands of followers (Onuch *et al.* 2023). Leading protest-mobilisation channels—such as NEXTA Live—posted guidelines on protest venues, the timing of gatherings and instructions on self-defence, as well as reports from citizens to disseminate information about ongoing events (Rudnik & Rönnblom 2024).

Additionally, local group chats on Telegram, co-moderated by citizens, drew together residents of the same towns or city districts, where they discussed the upcoming election and planned collective action (Mateo 2022). Moreover, compared to other platforms, Telegram was regarded as the safest and most convenient platform because it enabled the creation of news channels and both closed and open groups, thus combining the features of a social media and a messaging platform (Rogers 2020). Overall, just as in many other autocracies, Telegram has become increasingly attractive to citizens of Belarus due to the

³Interview 16, Vilnius, January 2023.

perceived provision of ‘social privacy’ and security afforded by its end-to-end encryption, disappearing messages function and the possibility to remain anonymous in group chats—functions that are unavailable on social media such as Facebook and TikTok (Akbari & Gabdulhakov 2019; Rogers 2020). Consequently, as Wijermars and Lokot (2022) argue, Telegram was perceived as an ‘ally’ of the protesters during the social mobilisations in Belarus. This argument is supported by actor–network theory.

Actor–network theory understands technology and people as mutually influencing the structuring, shaping and reinforcing of political processes, including protests (Baron & Gomez 2016). By ordering human lives, similarly to legal acts or political regulations, technology creates a framework with policies, power hierarchies and roles (Winner 1980, p. 131). When studying interactions between technology and social movements, researchers have focused primarily on emerging socio-technical phenomena, networking practices and the conceptualisation of social movements (Suchman 2007; van Dijck 2013; Baron & Gomez 2016). Socio-technical associations affect performativity, interact with various agents, and transform social movements and our understanding of them (Baron & Gomez 2016). Contrary to the conceptualisation of social networking platforms as tools and instruments for the leaders of and participants in social movements, assigning agency to technology opens a modality for interpreting platforms as ‘actants’ that affect relationships within socio-technical networks (Poell & van Dijck 2018). In this respect, platforms represent mediators capable of transforming actions and meanings (van Dijck 2013). While social networking platforms are not actors with the ability to perform human actions, their agency in dynamic networks is reflected in practices of interaction with other actors (Latour 2004; Law 2010; Sayes 2014). Instead of becoming a causal force, the agency of non-human actors implies an ability to ‘authorise, allow, encourage, permit, suggest, influence, forbid, render possible, and more’ (Latour 2004, p. 226). As summarised by Sayes (2014), agency is a characteristic of a human or non-human entity that makes a difference or promotes change in another entity or network. In line with an understanding of technology as possessing agency, Telegram is not seen as a ‘neutral intermediary’ in this study but as a silent or vocal mediator that ‘modifies relationships among other agents’ (Baron & Gomez 2016, p. 136).

Methodology

To examine the agencies invoked in the Belarusian protests of 2020, this study looks at multiple actors whose actions, relations and practices influenced or shaped the unfolding and realisation of political protests. Following the mapping of the socio-technical network, informed by previous research and interview materials, I conducted 38 semi-structured interviews with protesters who physically took part in the August 2020 protests in Belarus; activists and opposition politicians who formulated protest demands and mobilised the citizenry; and the moderators of the leading Telegram channels that transmitted protest-related messages at this time.

Among the informants were 16 protest participants; six representatives of opposition political structures such as Viktor Babaryka’s Headquarters, the Coordination Council of the Belarusian opposition, representatives of Siarhei Tsikhanouski and Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya; five representatives of electoral monitoring initiatives (Sumlennyja

Liudzi, Zubr, Holas) or other digital initiatives (BySol, ByHelp); four moderators of Telegram channels (NEXTA Live, Nexta, Belarus Golovnogo Mozga and Maja Kraina Belarus) and two moderators of open Telegram group chats for coordination of women's marches; and two journalists and three individual activists who were engaged in anti-government activity but not affiliated with any of the politicians, electoral monitoring initiatives or Telegram channels.⁴

The sample of respondents was strategic and focused on highlighting various practices and agencies of diverse actors of the protest network (Chulitskaya & Matonyte 2025). During the interviews, informants were asked to reflect upon their personal or professional interactions with Telegram during the protest events, the role of Telegram in protests, mobilisation and coordination practices during the protests, and issues of security and censorship. Informants were also able to reflect upon other aspects they found important, such as interaction with other social media, like Instagram, Facebook, Twitter and Viber, and the impact of the government's internet shutdown on the unfolding of the protests. The interviews were held between October 2022 and March 2023 and varied in length, between 35 and 117 minutes. The conversations were face-to-face (Vilnius, Warsaw, Berlin and Stockholm), apart from a few informants who preferred to talk *via* Zoom. Interviews were held in the Belarusian and Russian languages, of which I am a native speaker; all quotes presented in this article were translated by me. None of the informants currently residing in Belarus took part in interviews owing to acute security concerns identified by the author, human rights observers⁵ and the ethical commission that approved the study.⁶

Therefore, in discussing these interview materials I avoid any direct statements of demographic characteristics that may lead to their identification. Additionally, arrangements for the interview locations took into consideration the safety of both respondent and researcher. Interviews conducted *via* Zoom were secured through end-to-end encryption and recorded only on an external audio recorder. Prior to the interviews, respondents received a letter that outlined their rights, including the right to withdraw from the study. To avoid identification of participant's personal data, consent to participate in interviews was collected with oral confirmation of voluntary participation, recorded as a separate file and pseudonymised. During the interviews, the researcher avoided any references to prior collected materials, such as affiliations or names of previous respondents. Similarly, where respondents, in recalling the events of 2020, provided names of third persons, I have anonymised these mentions. Codified and pseudonymised interview materials are stored in the secure cloud provided by the researcher's affiliated university.

For many participants, the interview topic involved the discussion of sensitive issues due to traumatising experiences of emigration, previous imprisonment, the detention of relatives

⁴A full list of respondents can be found in the Appendix.

⁵'Human Rights Situation in Belarus', *Spring96*, February 2024, available at: <https://spring96.org/en/news/114680>, accessed 14 March 2024; *Belarus, Freedom in the World 2023*, Freedom House, available at: <https://freedomhouse.org/country/belarus/freedom-world/2023>, accessed 14 March 2024.

⁶Interviews were conducted following the guidelines of the Swedish Ethics Authority, once the author had received formal permission from that body.

and colleagues, political violence, and physical and mental trauma. Therefore, my insider position as a Belarusian who had closely monitored the protests and engaged with political initiatives and opposition leaders during the period of active civic resistance enabled access to the respondents and nurtured more intimate, in-person conversations (Edwards & Holland 2013). Other scholars who have interviewed Belarusians in relation to the events of 2020 have pointed out that obtaining interviews on such sensitive topics is possible precisely due to the interviewer's 'insider' position and mutual trust between respondents and interviewer (Chulitskaya & Matonyte 2025). Recognising my research role during the interviews and following the ethical and methodological standards of qualitative interview (Edwards & Holland 2013), it is also necessary to acknowledge my 'reflexivity' and positioning in relation to the respondents (Edwards & Holland 2013). For example, some respondents only opened up when I shared publicly unknown insider knowledge of certain practices and strategies employed during the Belarusian protests or when I situated myself as a part of the Belarusian prodemocratic movement. In other words, I was not neutral or a distant observant of the object but open to active reflexivity and interpretation (Edwards & Holland 2013; Chulitskaya & Matonyte 2025).

The interview materials inform the analysis section, which describes protest-related practices and the relations of protesters, activists, politicians and Telegram moderators with technology within the socio-technical network enacted during the Belarusian protests. As Fang argued when analysing the 2019 Hong Kong protests from an ANT perspective by following the actors, researchers can 'understand technology and society from an anti-deterministic perspective—development and changes are results of the changing relations among actors and actants, rather than something that is intrinsic and taken for granted' (Fang 2023, p. 3). At the same time, ANT does not offer a particular operationalisation of agency as a methodological concept. The interpretation of agency employed here follows the Latourian definition, according to which the 'agency of non-human actors implies an ability to "authorise, allow, encourage, permit, suggest, influence, forbid, render possible, and more"' (Sayes 2014, p. 141). The analysis section identifies protest-related practices of the actors of the protest network and then analyses the agencies emerging from these practices. Firstly, I present informants' reflections upon their engagement in protest movements. I then discuss what types of agency emerged *via* the protest-related practices of the outlined groups before analysing how these agencies mediated, altered or promoted actions of other actors within the protest networks (Sayes 2014). I understand agency as the capacity of participants or platforms to promote change and to render possible and shape the modes of action of other actors or that of a protest network as a whole (Latour 2004).

Mapping the network

In seeking to understand a protest network through its actors, I relied on respondents' observations and previous research for mapping out the network of protests in Belarus in 2020. I understand the socio-technical network that emerged during the Belarusian protests of 2020 as comprised of human actors—such as opposition political actors, electoral monitoring and other digital initiatives, a network of mobilisation and coordination Telegram channels, individual activists, and protesters and social media

users—along with non-human actors, such as the technology used to overcome the internet shutdown, apps created by independent initiatives, social networking platforms, the webpages of independent media channels, mobile phones, telecoms and internet infrastructure.

The Belarusian opposition comprised two main groups: the representatives of the formalised opposition, such as long-time party members, and politicians described by many interviewees as the ‘new opposition’, that is, politicians who first ran for election in 2020 (Bedford 2021).

Another group of actors behind the engagement of the electorate in both the election and in further protests were the three independent monitoring initiatives: Zubr (Zubr.in), Holas (Belarus2020.org) and Sumlennyja Liudzi (HonestPeople.by). As I learned during the interviews, all three initiatives were mainly composed of IT and marketing specialists who wanted to verify and monitor the election process, while avoiding any direct articulation of support to particular opposition candidates. All three initiatives heavily relied on digital tools to organise their activities and to protect themselves from potential security breaches. For example, Holas created a chatbot on Telegram and Viber as well as its own app, available to download from the Apple Store and Google Play.⁷ Zubr created its app to get around the potential blocking of their website by the authorities.⁸ Sumlennyja Liudzi employed numerous Telegram chats and chatbots to collect information about the election process and coordinate thousands of volunteers nationwide.⁹

A network of Telegram channels is the third data source in this study. One of the components of this network, LoveHata, was described by respondents as a closed Telegram chat, composed of activists, politicians and journalists, which served as a private communication platform for these actors, from where the protest was coordinated.¹⁰ LoveHata was created in 2018 before the protests to gather together political bloggers and independent media editors. However, at the start of the 2020 electoral campaign in Belarus, the chat was repurposed to coordinate messages regarding protest and to support people on the streets. At different stages, this chat included 10–20 people and became a platform for discussions about the protests. Political bloggers Ihar Losik (currently imprisoned), Eduard Palchys (currently imprisoned) and Stsiapan Putsila (currently in exile),¹¹ were among the founding members of the chat and the leaders of the largest mobilising Telegram channels. As the interviewees reported,¹² in 2020 LoveHata, which expanded to include opposition politicians and moderators of the largest mobilisation Telegram channels, became a core platform for decisions on protest mobilisation and coordination. At the same time, independent media actors, who were the

⁷Interview 25, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁸Interview 17, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁹Interview 34, online, March 2023.

¹⁰Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022; interview 18, online, January 2023; interview 26, Vilnius, January 2023.

¹¹‘Kryminal’ny perasled z pachatku vybarchai kampanii 2020. Spis ad pravaabarontsau “Viasny”’, *Spring* 96, 2021, available at: <https://spring96.org/be/news/99638>, accessed 14 March 2024.

¹²Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022; interview 18, online, January 2023; interview 26, Vilnius, January 2023.

initial members of the chat, could learn in advance about planned protests in order to arrive at locations on time or publish information about ongoing protests.

On the eve of election day, on 8 August, Telegram channels such as NEXTA Live, Nexta, Belarus Golovnogo Mozga and Maja Kraina Belarus, together with smaller channels such as Protesty v Mire and Belorusskij Poriadok, posted on how to prepare for an internet shutdown (for example, which apps to download to overcome the government blackout), instructions on self-defence (how to protect eyes from tear gas, what to wear during the protest), instructions on behaviour in case of detention and analyses of the political situation (Rudnik & Rönnblom 2024). These channels became nodes for protest coordination and information about the venues and timing of the protests. They also served as a diary of the Belarusian protests, distributing pictures and text reports about the ongoing activities and detentions of the protesters (Rudnik & Rönnblom 2024). During the first few days of protests, these channels posted approximately once a minute, with short breaks overnight. During the internet blackout, Telegram channels were one of the few sources producing live reports on the events in Belarus, either internationally or locally. Additionally, Telegram had emerged as a convenient app, combining the social aspects and features of anonymous messaging with end-to-end encryption and the ability to delete messages at the receiving end (Rogers 2020).

In the next section, I follow the actors in the network outlined above to examine the protest-related practices described by the interview respondents.

Protest practices and agencies of protest participants

In interviews with protest participants, I asked them about their protest-related practices and the relationship of those practices to Telegram and other technologies. The interviewees' reflections can be summarised through their roles as news disseminators, peer educators and coordinators.

For many, informing their relatives, friends on Telegram group chats and followers about specific occurrences on the streets and the timing of upcoming manifestations was seen as a mission: 'Among my friends and relatives, I was the only one with access to the internet because they hadn't managed to install a VPN, so I was forwarding the news for them, everything that I'd read on NEXTA'.¹³ Often, one person with access to the internet stayed at home and informed the rest of their circle of friends and relatives about the movements of the police and changes in the locations of protests. These occurred through mobile connections because protesters often had no internet access. Internet access was often most problematic in smaller villages close to the cities. One informant explained that, for this reason, they drove to the nearest city (Hrodna) and 'found a wired ethernet port and downloaded videos from Minsk'. Back in the village the informant showed them to all his acquaintances. The respondent clarified that it was important to share the protests in Minsk, where the number of people on the streets was the largest.¹⁴

¹³Interview 3, Berlin, October 2022.

¹⁴Interview 9, Stockholm, December 2022.

For other protest participants, it was important to document protests and send these materials to the independent media, such as television channel *Belsat*, the online newspapers *Svaboda*, *Euraradio*, or Telegram channels, such as NEXTA Live and MKB: ‘We recorded drones and police cars or buses with closed doors to inform [people] where the police were’.¹⁵

Protesters also engaged in news dissemination through private postings on their Facebook and Instagram accounts: ‘I’ve published a lot on Instagram Stories with captions like “You know what to do tomorrow!”’, without directly calling for people to join protests’.¹⁶ One informant, a young protester from Minsk, felt they had a mission to inform others about the ongoing political situation: ‘My main role was informative, as I worked in marketing and at that point worked with bloggers in SMM [social media marketing], so I knew how to distribute the messages’.¹⁷ The respondent highlighted that they had a capacity to persuade friends and neighbours to support the protest movement.

The practices of protesters were not limited to distributing information online among their networking circle, but also included translating political narratives into their audience’s language (Latour 2004), promoting these narratives, and activating protest engagement among their followers:

I posted everything related to how to participate in the election, highlighted disinformation distributed by the authorities. Because I understood that the majority of people who follow me on Instagram are not interested in politics or reading analytics. I wanted to make them think, and I had to do it in their language.¹⁸

Another practice among protest participants was the education of relatives and friends. For example, interviewed protesters mentioned installing a VPN and the Telegram app on the smartphones of their older relatives, teaching them how to use the platform, or subscribing parents to independent YouTube channels to consume news ‘and then the YouTube algorithms did the rest of the job’.¹⁹ Two informants mentioned more rigorous preparation for sharing their knowledge with their community. One informant had downloaded PDF files posted on the NEXTA Live Telegram channel and on the human rights defenders’ webpages (for example, the Human Rights Centre Viasna) about how to behave during detention.²⁰ Another respondent compiled a PDF file describing the first steps upon encountering the police, which they distributed within their network of friends. A distinct example of collective engagement in protest activities was mentioned by a respondent from Minsk, whose parents resided in a small town nearby: ‘Once I went to my village and took leaflets to my parents, and at night my dad distributed hundreds of leaflets with information on how to take a picture on voting day and upload it on Holas’.²¹

¹⁵Interview 6, online, October 2022.

¹⁶Interview 13, Vilnius, January 2023.

¹⁷Interview 20, Warsaw, December 2022.

¹⁸Interview 20, Warsaw, December 2022.

¹⁹Interview 20, Warsaw, December 2022.

²⁰Interview 3, Berlin, October 2022.

²¹Interview 20, Warsaw, December 2022.

Local Telegram group chats that emerged after the first active days of protests were seen by protest participants as a nodal point for protest coordination. Almost every protester I interviewed was a member of at least one group chat on Telegram or Viber. In the local group chats, protesters discussed suggestions on protest locations and protest-related ideas published on the leading Telegram channels, planned local protests, and collected money to pay the fines imposed on neighbours detained at protests and charged by the courts under the administrative code.

Within the local group chats, Belarusians built new contacts and closer ties: ‘With my neighbour from the local chat, we coordinated who would stay with the kids, mine and hers, and took turns protesting. For us, it was important that one of us went to protest’.²² Another informant, who at the time of the protests was a parent of a 6-month-old child, explained that in their family the wife was attending protests more often because, if she were detained, as the mother of a young child she would be released quickly, in contrast to the husband, who could have faced longer detention.²³

Horizontal protest coordination and organisation involved providing physical assistance to the protest movement. One of the informants referred to such community practices as a ‘story about understanding ourselves as actors in politics’.²⁴ Informants described such practices as delivering water to protest venues, collecting hygiene products and clothes for detained peer-protesters, and patrolling their residential areas:

One day, I had to travel to the detention centre at Zhodzina and deliver clothes and hygiene products to people detained at protests. And when I saw the protests on the way, I thought it would be nice to join, but I also knew that I needed to deliver the packages from the detainees’ relatives.²⁵

One of the interviewees mentioned that, on the first days of protests, they would open doors to protesters hiding from the police. This person later published a Facebook post encouraging people living in the city centre to leave the doors of their houses open for the physical security of the protesters:

The thought to keep doors open to protesters to shield them from the police came by itself. But then I read the same instructions on Telegram. And then, to inform others, I posted a message on Facebook calling on my friends to leave the doors of their houses open. Also, without mentioning my address, I said that I could host people in the Stella area.²⁶

Often it was unclear what kind of assistance was required at a particular moment; therefore, some protesters would ‘take a car and travel around the city to help with anything we could. We were unsure what exactly to do’.²⁷ Several interviewees mentioned the function of local

²²Interview 19, Warsaw, December 2022.

²³Interview 20, Warsaw, December 2022.

²⁴Interview 8, online, December 2022.

²⁵Interview 4, Berlin, October 2022.

²⁶Interview 2, Berlin, October 2022.

²⁷Interview 15, online, January 2023.

‘guardians’. Within local group chats, people would arrange patrols in their districts looking out for the police.²⁸ One informant elaborated: ‘We had men who monitored the yard and district one by one, and called us, neighbours, to inform us when the police were nearby. They took this initiative by themselves; they were responsible for controlling the territory’.²⁹

Protest participants often mentioned that during the first days of protests, they checked on locations and the timing of protests on Telegram. Decisions about participation often needed to be made on the spot; being out on the streets, without internet access, was described by one participant as ‘being an iceberg in the ocean’.³⁰ For others, however, Telegram channels played only a weak role in coordination, because the protests and local chains of solidarity that played a ‘decisive role in the Belarusian revolution’³¹ occurred without local coordination from NEXTA: ‘NEXTA never posted any coordination instructions for our town, we just went out to discover what was going on’.³² The feeling of unity and solidarity significantly influenced protest mobilisation because ‘many people [saw] that there [were] many like-minded individuals and decided that they were not alone’.³³ At the same time, some respondents stressed that Telegram channels became ‘leaders of the leaderless revolution’ because ‘there was no one else’.³⁴ Interestingly, some informants speculated that it was the internet shutdown itself that had propelled people onto the streets: ‘If the authorities hadn’t blocked the internet, people wouldn’t have come out on the streets. After all, people didn’t have the internet during the French Revolution’.³⁵

Reflecting on the agencies associated with the above-described practices, most of the interviews revealed protesters as performing agency through disseminating information, that is educating and coordinating peer-protesters and relatives. Protesters exercised their agency through re-posting and re-sharing news that appeared on Telegram channels and independent media websites. Some of the protesters saw their central function in terms of assistance rather than direct participation: guarding local areas against the police, delivering water to protest venues, distributing leaflets containing information about upcoming activities, and opening their doors to protesters who were hiding from the police. These practices enabled the engagement of broader groups within the protest movement and spurred the feeling of a collective movement.

Protest practices and agencies of activists, opposition politicians and Telegram moderators

During the interviews with activists, opposition politicians and moderators of Telegram channels, I asked informants to reflect upon their functions and the role of technology, specifically Telegram, in performing their activist and political tasks during the Belarusian

²⁸Interview 6, online, October 2022; interview 4, Berlin, October 2022; interview 19, Warsaw, December 2022; interview 35, Warsaw, March 2023.

²⁹Interview 6, online, October 2022.

³⁰Interview 27, Vilnius, January 2023.

³¹Interview 11, online, January 2023.

³²Interview 7, Stockholm, November 2022.

³³Interview 14, online, January 2023.

³⁴Interview 19, Warsaw, December 2022.

³⁵Interview 27, Vilnius, January 2023.

protests of 2020. One of the central functions of politicians and activists was raising awareness about the country's political situation before election day. For political activists and monitoring organisations, the mission was to attract people to the polling stations and involve them in flash-mobs, such as wearing a white armband as a symbol of support for the opposition candidate, which also had the practical goal of counting how many supporters came to vote for Tsikhanouskaya, the only oppositional candidate registered to run as a candidate by the Belarusian Central Electoral Commission. According to an activist from Holas, the alternative vote-counting platform, 'Our goal was to show that people's fates are in their own hands'.³⁶

Informants often used the words 'education and enlightenment' when reflecting upon their protest-related practices.³⁷ Bloggers and representatives of monitoring initiatives saw their function as explaining electoral processes to ordinary citizens and sharing instructions on becoming an electoral observer during the elections. At the time of the protests, bloggers and journalists were also sharing their thoughts on private pages on social media, such as Facebook and Instagram: 'On the 9th of August I posted a piece about why people should go and vote. ... I also added that, if the votes are stolen, we need to go out on the streets and stand up for our right to free and fair elections'.³⁸

For the moderators of Telegram channels, a key function was educating people about how to participate in the protests safely. For example, Telegram channel Belarus Golovnoho Mozga (Belarus of the Brain) compiled materials on protest participation and self-defence: 'We've pinched advice from human rights organisations on how to behave during an unlawful detention and how to defend yourself, which article of the Constitution to appeal to; then we created visual material from it, like PDF files or posters that were later distributed on our channel'.³⁹

The moderators of the Telegram channels described how their duties evolved as the electoral campaign turned into a protest movement. Thus, in some cases, Telegram channels had existed long before the electoral campaign as a form of national media posting news about ongoing events and occasionally promoting cultural and social events across the country. These channels reposted news from elsewhere—traditional media sources and individual reports—as well as doing their own reporting as 'citizen journalists'. Only two of the moderators and informants of these Telegram channels described themselves as professional journalists.⁴⁰ As grievances against the government intensified across Belarusian society during the electoral campaign, many of these Telegram channels became politicised:

I was moderating the student Telegram channel BGU97, which started as a platform for discussing the protection of students' rights and various events. But I've been publishing a lot of protest-related

³⁶Interview 25, Vilnius, January 2023.

³⁷Interview 23, Vilnius, January 2023.

³⁸Interview 13, Vilnius, January 2023.

³⁹Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022.

⁴⁰Interview 38, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023.

information since the beginning of August. Then we informed students about the ongoing protests and organised our own.⁴¹

None of the Telegram moderators interviewed could identify the moment when their role as news disseminators began to overlap with protest coordination and mobilisation functions. One editor stated:

At some point, we started to use the channel as an instrument. One of the examples is when we sent incorrect guidelines on protest venues just to trick the police, who were hunting protesters. We did it so that people could hold protests at their current locations and not risk detention.⁴²

Some Telegram channels that existed before 2020 as blogs were the first to grow into the largest platforms for protest mobilisation. By the start of the electoral campaign, the moderators of these channels had become skilled in utilising Telegram's specific affordances, such as chatbots. Chatbots on Telegram are an interface that mimics human conversation, assisted by the prewritten messages that are sent out to the users as they fulfil a particular action, such as pressing a button or writing a message in the chat window. In 2020, the largest mobilisation Telegram channels, such as NEXTA Live, Nexta, Belarus Golovnogo Mozga and Maja Kraina Belarus introduced chatbots for the automatic collection of information from the users and, according to the respondents, allowed for anonymity of the users. One moderator, who moderated and produced political content for several Telegram channels, explained the role of moderators in teaching people how to use Telegram professionally: 'Bloggers already knew how to format texts according to the platform and work with media files. We also helped others transfer to Telegram; for example, we provided instructions on creating feedback chatbots for independent media that had just started to transfer to Telegram'.⁴³

In summer 2020, Telegram channels acquired a new function: providing reports on ongoing events during the electoral campaign and republishing messages, such as text reports or photo and video materials, received through the feedback chatbots. During the peak days of the protests, when the authorities shut down the internet, Telegram channel moderators received massive numbers of reports from citizens on the streets. For the moderators, every message potentially contributed to mobilising people to join the movement and participate in the protests; therefore, publishing updates received through the feedback chatbots was very important.

To perform this live news role, Telegram moderators relied on citizens on the streets, who informed the channels about ongoing events. For example, the channels published requests for people to anonymously share pictures, texts and audio files, which were later posted. In this way, Telegram channels aggregated protest-related news and content that was often unique compared to the mainstream independent media with a large audience (for example, TUT.by, Onliner, Nasha Niva), which mostly relied on reports from journalists.

⁴¹Interview 5, online, October 2022.

⁴²Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022.

⁴³Interview 18, online, January 2023.

Aware of their broad outreach and ‘realising that opposition politicians had no plans to organise their own protests’,⁴⁴ Telegram moderators began to organise protests by publishing the times and venues of gatherings. This included, for example, selecting venues that could host large numbers of people and which had safe exit routes: ‘During the first few days, we spent hours looking at Google Maps and analysing where it would be safe to protest. That’s how we came up with Stella, a monument in the centre of Minsk, as a venue; it was a relatively safe and large location with exit routes’.⁴⁵ At the same time, Telegram moderators highlighted that their coordination was often limited to suggestions rather than direct instructions. As one of the Telegram channel moderators illustrates, in their communication with the protesters ‘We would never write: “walk 100 meters to the square, then turn right” etc.’.⁴⁶

Various informants disagreed about the role of Telegram channels in setting the protest agenda. While political activists believed that protest demands ‘were the messages that were collectively formulated, and Telegram channels just published this information’,⁴⁷ most of the interviewed moderators and activists of electoral and digital initiatives argued that many of the proposals related to protest locations and timing, wording of the protest demands, and ideas concerning mobilising protesters published in local group chats emerged within a narrow circle of people, for example, in the above-mentioned private Telegram chat LoveHata.⁴⁸ One such example is the establishment of local Telegram group chats. One respondent said that most of the local group chats were usually sparked by one local blogger.⁴⁹ Additionally, certain respondents argue that the impetus behind the largest protests came from LoveHata.⁵⁰ Participants generated ideas for upcoming protests, locations and the protest agenda within the chat. Decisions on protest coordination and publishing calls to action in the leading Telegram channels were made collectively in the chat LoveHata, and, in case of disagreement over the proposed location, timing or protest demands, moderators of the Telegram channels, who were also the LoveHata chat members, had no obligation to publish calls to action approved by the rest of the participants.⁵¹ The leading role of the chat member as protest coordinators was confirmed by the majority of informants. When the protests turned into regular Sunday marches, members of LoveHata had a deadline to post information about marches (location, theme and timing): ‘Sometimes we had situations when it was already Friday, and we knew that protests should happen on Sunday, but we still had no idea what exactly to suggest’.⁵²

⁴⁴Interview 18, online, January 2023.

⁴⁵Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022.

⁴⁶Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022.

⁴⁷Interview 33, Warsaw, March 2023.

⁴⁸Interview 17, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022; interview 18, online, January 2023; interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 23, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁴⁹Interview 18, online, January 2023.

⁵⁰Interview 17, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022; interview 18, online, January 2023; interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 23, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁵¹Interview 38, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁵²Interview 18, online, January 2023.

Some protests were organised outside the infrastructure described above, including women's marches held across the country in August 2020. As the organisers of these marches later clarify in the interviews, the idea to mobilise women in solidarity chains and marches emerged as a reaction to police violence and detention of their male relatives who took part in protests.⁵³ The women's marches started with the female activists, who gathered in a small group outside the food market Kamarouka in Minsk. The two leading activists interviewed for this study published pictures of the women's solidarity chain on Twitter and Instagram, and used their contacts in independent media to make it 'viral': 'We wanted to change the tone of voice from violence to kindness. I read about civic movements, and I knew that a positive image of a movement is extremely important'.⁵⁴ On 11 August, the organisers of women's marches created an open Telegram group that, within 24 hours, grew to 10,000 users and was described by the informants as a 'chaotic community that somehow generated ideas for further marches and was able to self-organise'.⁵⁵

When I asked informants to reflect upon their role in coordinating the protests, one initially called themselves 'the brain of this revolution', but later, perhaps overcome by modesty, said that they would rather define themselves as a coordinator and initiator than an organiser.⁵⁶ Other informants reacted critically to suggestions that Telegram channels shaped how the protests unfolded. In the words of one Telegram editor, 'People didn't do something because we said so, [but because] it aligned with their thoughts and feelings. I don't think people would listen to us if we said "surround the presidential palace"'.⁵⁷ Similarly, another respondent said that 'it was impossible to write something and expect people to blindly follow it. People were ready to take responsibility and take action'.⁵⁸

Agencies of the activists, opposition politicians and Telegram moderators were manifested through engaging in information gathering, content creation, re-sharing and cross-posting, thus reinforcing the nationwide coordination and organisation of the protest movement. In the case of Telegram moderators, their agency in coordinating protests enabled live coordination of the protest movement, the efficiency of which was surprising to the moderators themselves.

Similarly, opposition politicians and Telegram moderators discussed protest-framing practices and the formulation of protest demands, the key role of which was to raise awareness and mobilise Belarusians to participate in elections, flash-mobs and protests. Thus, in promoting political engagement, raising awareness, and framing protest ideas for a broader audience, these publishing practices served to activate agency of translation (Latour 2004).

One of the key forms of agency enacted by the people behind the screens, those who were leading Telegram channels, was the coordination of protesters' movements by distributing information about the locations and venues of protests. By proposing locations and

⁵³Interview 23, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 31, online, March 2023.

⁵⁴Interview 31, online, March 2023.

⁵⁵Interview 23, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 31, online, March 2023.

⁵⁶Interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁵⁷Interview 16, Vilnius, November 2022.

⁵⁸Interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023.

venues through their channels, the moderators promoted strategies that were then applied by other actors and protesters on the streets. At the same time, when analysing the practices of informants, it becomes clear that this agency, which was exerted by Telegram moderators located abroad, would have been impossible without close coordination with protesters on the ground and feedback chatbots acting as mediators in aggregating news.

The role of Telegram in sustaining protests

The primary advantage of Telegram as a protest mediation platform, as highlighted by informants, was its aggregation function: it provided access to the news from independent media and reports from Telegram channels, and allowed for participation in open local group chats and closed chats with friends and relatives. Compared to independent media websites, Telegram channels verified their information less often, which enabled quicker distribution of reports from ongoing protests: 'I lived on Telegram during those days. We all had a need to know how and where we would gather; how many people were there. Telegram is much more convenient than reading independent media. When you look at one channel, you see reposts from other channels'.⁵⁹ News aggregation from all over the country became possible through the specific affordances of the platform, which allowed the creation of feedback chatbots: 'I think using Telegram bots was a very clever move by Telegram channels to aggregate the news'.⁶⁰ Rapid news distribution also had an impact on the 'documentation of truth'.⁶¹ As one informant related, Telegram became a source for finding out about 'the authorities' violent behaviour against the protesters, which opened the eyes of many Belarusians and triggered them to join the protests'.⁶² At the same time, protest participants from smaller towns or villages mentioned the role of Viber, a messenger app that was 'the main messenger before everyone downloaded Telegram'⁶³ in these locations; however, Telegram was part of discussions of events on Viber: 'Someone would send links from Telegram to our Viber chats'.⁶⁴

Reflecting upon the role of technology in general, specifically Telegram, some interviewees stressed the inevitability of the platform's integration into the protest movement. This reasoning was commonly articulated by representatives of political and monitoring initiatives. For example, the representative from the headquarters of Babaryka clarified: 'These were not unique technologies. These technologies were part of society; we just had to select the correct ones based on our professional experience'.⁶⁵ Another aspect highlighted by informants was the effectiveness of the platform in rapid mobilisation for support and celebration, an instance of 'technology reinforcing the social': 'It's essential to celebrate small victories, and we did it constantly through campaigning on our Telegram channel because I think, when people have verification of

⁵⁹Interview 15, online, January 2023.

⁶⁰Interview 1, Stockholm, October 2022.

⁶¹Interview 37, online, March 2023.

⁶²Interview 10, Stockholm, January 2023.

⁶³Interview 9, Stockholm, December 2022.

⁶⁴Interview 9, Stockholm, December 2022; interview 19, Warsaw, December 2022; interview 10, Stockholm, January 2023.

⁶⁵Interview 32, online, January 2023.

some actions being undertaken together and successfully, this causes positive emotions and people want to repeat it'.⁶⁶

Throughout the interviews, many informants mentioned the aspect of security: 'I realised how well Telegram works in terms of security. You could be there under a false name and block calls from those who aren't in your contacts'.⁶⁷ For protesters, Telegram security was a motivation to take part in political discussions with members of open group chats. For activists and politicians, Telegram's security was a decisive factor in selecting the platform for communicating and transmitting political messages.

Regarding Telegram's role in organising protests, informants described the platform as a source of coordination instructions. While many interviewed protesters were sceptical of some narratives distributed on channels such as NEXTALive due to cases of misinformation about the location of police that could put protesters in danger, they used the channel as a point of departure for coordination: 'Telegram channels gathered people in one place'.⁶⁸ Most of the interview participants were members of local group chats where self-organisation occurred: 'First, it was a chat for district Serabryanka, later it had 10,000 people, then smaller chats were emerging, like Serabryanka, Serabryanka 2, Serabryanka 3, as local chats for a particular house. There, people discussed their strategies for the upcoming protest'.⁶⁹ Both in the local open chats and in secure chats among friends, colleagues and protesters, people discussed news and participation in upcoming marches.

Another example of protest mediation by Telegram raised by informants related to larger mobilisation chats, such as the above-mentioned chat on the coordination of women's marches that turned into a 'flood feed' but 'somehow worked' for planning activities, coming up with themes such as: 'Do we wear white today or do we take flowers to today's protest?'.⁷⁰ Two contradictory positions on Telegram as a mobilising platform emerged. While interviewees argued that Telegram channels were not limited to reporting, but 'suggested what to do',⁷¹ others insisted, 'Telegram channels suggested where to gather but not what to do'.⁷²

As a mediation platform, Telegram was seen by interview informants as an important element of the socio-technical network because it enabled information exchange between politicians, moderators and protesters through feedback chatbots, local group chats, and both closed and open Telegram groups and channels.

The way in which multiple respondents reflected upon relations between various human actors and social media, mainly Telegram, illustrates the horizontality and networking structure of the Belarusian protests. In a techno-social-setting perception of protests as a 'revolution of multiples', 'a community where everyone simultaneously generated

⁶⁶Interview 21, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁶⁷Interview 10, Stockholm, January 2023.

⁶⁸Interview 11, online, January 2023.

⁶⁹Interview 6, online, October 2022.

⁷⁰Interview 23, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁷¹Interview 29, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁷²Interview 3, Berlin, October 2022; interview 12, Vilnius, January 2023; interview 19, Warsaw, December 2022.

ideas',⁷³ the socio-technical network acquires deeper connotations of a network where multiple actors collaborate and contest the enactment of that network.

The agency of the human participants in the protest movement was closely intertwined with the social networking platforms that provided forums for the discussion of the political situation in both closed and open group chats, brief live updates and coordination instructions. Additionally, the ability to communicate anonymously within a relatively secure platform, Telegram, enhanced practices of self-organisation through local group chats, the organisation of local protest and the collection of money on behalf of detained protesters residing in the same area. Reacting to requests to send information about ongoing events, protesters added to protest documentation with their own personal visual materials and text reports. In this way, Telegram aggregated materials from protesters that later circulated back to them as brief news updates. Finally, feedback chatbots became a source from which Telegram moderators could gather feedback on protest framing, allowing them to better understand the direction in which the movement was developing, and therefore correct and modify protest communication. Following informants' perception of Telegram's role in the Belarusian protests, the platform's most significant agentic role was in news aggregation and dissemination, stimulating decentralised self-organisation, coordinating mass demonstrations, and providing a sense of security to protesters who actively engaged with Telegram's channels and chats due to the above-mentioned security features of the platform (Rogers 2020).

Protesters mentioned the role of YouTube, Viber and Instagram with assisting the dissemination of information, communicating with smaller groups of friends, and being able to access messages from political leaders. At the same time, reflecting upon routines of protest, recalling their daily practices during the peak days of protest in August 2020, most interviewees agreed that it was primarily Telegram that had assisted and enabled coordination and communication. Some informants believed that Telegram had such a strong influence on protest coordination and organisation because it was already part of the daily life of Belarusians prior to the protests.⁷⁴ Others argued that the platform had a less significant presence before the protests, and it was the choice of activists and media experts, motivated by Telegram's security and specific affordances, to use the platform, thus popularising it during the protest period.

Overall, Telegram enabled new modes of action, allowing mobilisation, coordination and interaction between multiple actors (Winner 1980; Latour 2007; Sayes 2014). In this way, Telegram mediated protest routines at the peak of the political resistance in Belarus that started in the summer of 2020. From being a news platform, Telegram became a protest organisation app that combined features of social media—such as public channels, and collective open and closed groups—with the characteristics of a messaging platform, with the ability to aggregate news through the unique Telegram function of feedback chatbots. The platform allowed protesters to connect with each other, enabled secure communication channels for opposition politicians and the mobilisation channels' moderators abroad with protesting Belarusians, and enabled the simultaneous distribution

⁷³Interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023.

⁷⁴Interview 32, online, January 2023; interview 22, Vilnius, January 2023.

of live updates from across the country. Telegram's mediation of this protest episode appears to be closely associated with the multiple agencies of human actors in co-producing protest content, disseminating mobilisation tactics, and physically taking part in resistance or providing assistance to protesters.

Conclusion

This article aimed to explore the agencies invoked within a socio-technical network that emerged during the Belarusian protests of 2020 by examining practices of protest activism and by identifying the human and non-human agencies triggered by these practices. The perceptions of protesters, opposition politicians, activists and moderators of protest-mobilising channels illustrate the various agencies of human actors and highlight the complexity of this network of multiple entities of various sizes (van Dijck 2013). In particular, the analysis has identified the emergence of multiple agencies—those of protesters, protest coordinators and activists—during the Belarusian protests of 2020. A complex network of humans and their non-human counterparts (Telegram, voting app Holas, mobile phones, Instagram, Viber, internet connections), within which each element exercised various forms of agency, enabled the collective and decentralised reinforcement of protest coordination and organisation.

My analysis of the interview data shows that numerous protest practices, events that occurred during the protest episode, and horizontal connections built within the network would have been impossible in that form if any one of the elements had been absent. Most informants exercised their agency by raising awareness about the political situation; by coordinating protest (in terms of functional coordination and the framing of themes and protest demands); or by aggregating, verifying and disseminating news. Although it is difficult to assess the effects of agencies in relation to dissemination, peer education and coordination, the interviewees highlighted how these practices influenced their relatives' or friends' values and political engagement. Interconnection and close ties between network members were enhanced by the mediation of Telegram, but also by those activists and moderators behind the screens who collected feedback, framed protest demands, and distributed messages related to coordination and motivation. Telegram widened the arsenal of prodemocratic movement, influenced the creation of new arenas for protest-related discussions and content distribution, and fostered shared leadership and coordination practices among the members of the socio-technical network that emerged during the Belarusian protests in 2020.

This is the first study to engage with the perceptions, reflections and practices of the actors in the Belarusian protests of 2020 and to uncover their experiences as protesters, activists, politicians, and moderators and administrators of Telegram channels. A closer examination of interaction practices between social networking platforms and political protesters would enable a broader understanding of modern protest movements and uncover labour practices related to protest organisation and realisation.

ALESIA RUDNIK, PhD Candidate in Political Science, Karlstad University, Karlstad 65188, Sweden. *Email:* alesia.rudnik@kau.se; alesia.rudnik@gmail.com
 <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-0040-0293>

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Appendix. Table of respondents

	Group	Gender	Location	Date
1	Protest participant	Female	Stockholm	October 2022
2	Protest participant	Male	Berlin	October 2022
3	Protest participant	Female	Berlin	October 2022
4	Protest participant	Female	Berlin	October 2022
5	Protest participant	Female	Online	October 2022
6	Protest participant	Female	Online	October 2022
7	Protest participant	Female	Stockholm	November 2022
8	Protest participant	Male	Online	December 2022
9	Protest participant	Male	Stockholm	December 2022
10	Protest participant	Female	Stockholm	January 2023
11	Protest participant	Male	Online	January 2023
12	Protest participant	Female	Vilnius	January 2023
13	Individual activist	Female	Vilnius & online	January 2023
14	Protest participant	Male	Online	January 2023
15	Protest participant	Male	Online	January 2023
16	Moderator of Telegram Channel	Male	Vilnius & online	November 2022 and January 2023
17	Electoral monitoring initiative or other digital initiative	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
18	Moderator of Telegram Channel	Male	Online	January 2023
19	Protest participant	Female	Warsaw	December 2022
20	Protest participant	Female	Warsaw	December 2022
21	Electoral monitoring initiative or other digital initiative	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
22	Moderator of Telegram Channel	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
23	Moderator of open Telegram group chat for coordination of women's marches	Female	Vilnius	January 2023
24	Electoral monitoring initiative or other digital initiative	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
25	Electoral monitoring initiative or other digital initiative	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
26	Opposition politician	Female	Vilnius	January 2023
27	Opposition politician	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
28	Individual activist	Female	Vilnius	January 2023
29	Individual activist	Male	Vilnius	January 2023
30	Journalist	Female	Vilnius	January 2023
31	Moderator of open Telegram group chat for coordination of women's marches	Female	Online	March 2023
32	Opposition politician	Female	Online	January 2023
33	Opposition politician	Male	Warsaw	March 2023
34	Electoral monitoring initiative or other digital initiative	Female	Online	March 2023
35	Journalist	Female	Warsaw	March 2023
36	Opposition politician	Female	Online	February 2023
37	Opposition politician	Male	Online	March 2023
38	Moderator of Telegram Channel	Female	Vilnius	January 2023